

from the truth. You can pursue a financially free life and also only put your money into missions you support.

Ethical investing — investing only in ways that align with your values and morals — is a legitimate investing strategy (covered in more detail in [chapter 8](#)). While some investments include companies that engage in warfare, tobacco use and animal testing, over the past two decades there's been a shift towards ESG investing — investing in companies that place an emphasis on environmental, social and governance factors. In 2015, only \$5 billion was invested into environmentally sustainable funds in the US, but by 2020 that increased to over \$51 billion — and it's only growing stronger.

By being an investor, you can vote with your money. You can choose what types of companies deserve your hard-earned cash, and companies will take notice. Brands that promote plant-based meals or clean energy may be on your list, or perhaps you really want to back companies that have at least a 50 per cent female/male ratio in leadership — whatever causes are important to you, you can push for further change with investing. You can also vote by avoiding investing in certain companies based on their poor ESG ratings, or practices that you don't agree with.

If a large distribution company, for example, chooses to not let their workers unionise, or perhaps encourages them to stay in warehouses during a tornado, you can vote with your money by not investing in their company, or pulling out your investments, making it known that you don't support that kind of work environment and, for heaven's sake, to let people go home during natural disasters.

An example of investing for change was seen in April 2010. British Petroleum had a devastating oil spill in the Gulf of Mexico after their Deepwater Horizon drilling rig exploded. Piercing images showed the disgustingly vast amount of oil spreading across the ocean. Photos of the wildlife drenched in oil are scenes I will never forget. BP's shares dropped 51 per cent in 40 days on the New York Stock Exchange, losing almost \$100 billion in value. Investors 'punished' the brand by pulling their money out, sending a clear message to BP and other oil companies that these kinds of mistakes would not be tolerated.

It's no surprise that millennial and Gen Z consumer spending is increasingly moving towards purchases that align with their values; thrifting, vegan